

SSB INTERNATIONAL • PBB POLISUR (DOW) EXPORT OPERATION • BAHÍA BLANCA

Container Detention CRM

Turning a runaway cost – **USD 588k in 11 months** – into a visible, managed, declining cost. And replicating the solution across Dow's operations in Latin America.

1. Executive summary

The problem. The operation's detention cost has tripled: from an average of USD 25k per month in 2025 to USD 77k per month in 2026, peaking at USD 117k in April. Accumulated over August 2025 – June 2026: USD 588,370. At the current pace, 2026 would close above USD 900k. The root cause is not operational but one of visibility: with manual spreadsheet tracking, a delay is discovered only when the invoice already exists.

The solution. An in-house CRM that follows every container from empty pickup to closure, computes the remaining free days per carrier daily, and raises alerts before the first dollar of charges. The platform is in its second version, deployed to production and validated against the operation's full history; internal test-mode rollout is starting now – execution risk is zero.

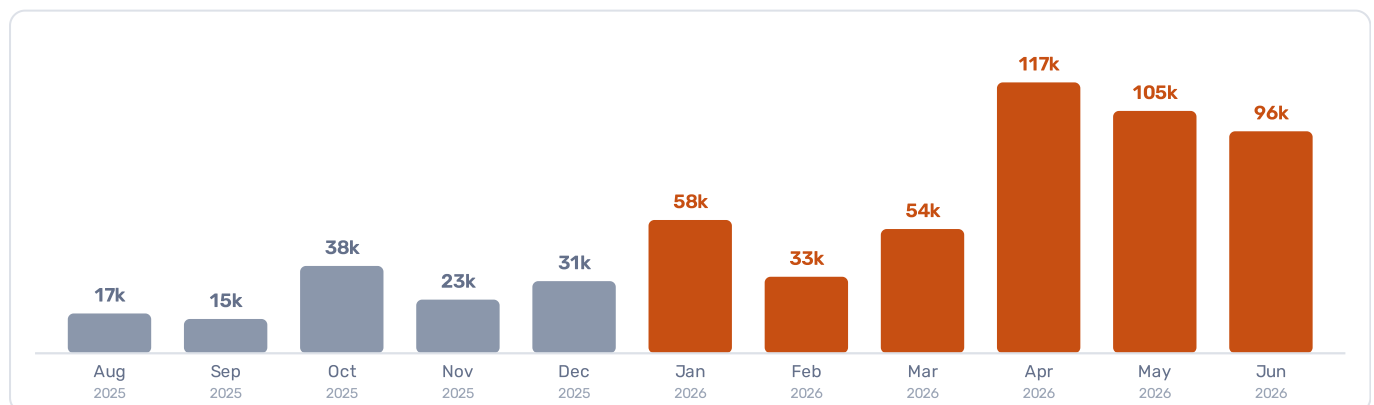
The opportunity. Between USD 118k and 206k per year of addressable savings (conservative and achievable scenarios), plus recoveries from disputing wrongly invoiced charges. Operating investment is marginal: minimal-cost cloud infrastructure, no per-user licenses.

The scale. The architecture is 100% parameterized – carriers, tariffs, free time, plants, depots and language are configuration, not code – and the interface operates in Spanish, Portuguese and English. The same system replicates to any Dow containerized export operation in Latin America, each with its own baseline.

The ask. Formal adoption of the system as the operation's single system of record, with a 4-week value-capture plan and monthly measurement of savings against the historical baseline already loaded.

2. The problem in numbers

Every container picked up from a depot has a free-time allowance granted by the carrier; once exceeded, a daily tariff in USD is invoiced per container. With 300–400 containers per month, four active carriers with different allowances and tariffs, and two plants with transfers between them, manual tracking stopped being enough. The monthly series of actual costs shows it clearly:



Closing month	Closed operations	With delay	Cost (USD)
Aug 2025	241	52	17,250
Sep 2025	355	75	14,865
Oct 2025	440	118	37,840
Nov 2025	212	86	23,250
Dec 2025	382	164	31,260
Jan 2026	161	100	57,750
Feb 2026	146	77	33,155
Mar 2026	310	178	53,835
Apr 2026	224	194	117,355
May 2026	177	111	105,000
Jun 2026	214	100	96,175
Period total	2,880	1,259	588,370*

* Source: the system's own database (closed-costs view), cutoff 07-07-2026. The total includes July 2026 in progress (18 operations, USD 635), not listed as a row because it is a partial month. Averages: 2025 ≈ USD 25k/month; 2026 (Jan–Jun) ≈ USD 77k/month.

Where the cost is concentrated

Analysis of the 1,259 containers that incurred detention charges in the period shows the cost does not come from short, unavoidable delays, but from containers that sat weeks past their deadline without anyone noticing in time:

Days past free time	Containers	Delay days	Cost (USD)	% of cost
1 to 5 days	459	1,183	38,975	7%
6 to 15 days	425	4,280	147,055	25%
16 days or more	375	12,102	402,340	68%

The 375 containers in the last band spent an average of **32 days** generating charges. A delay of that length is not a one-off accident: it is a container nobody was watching. That is exactly the pattern an alerting system cuts at the root.

3. The savings opportunity

Each avoided delay day is worth USD 33 on average (up to USD 85 per day depending on the carrier). Over the analyzed period, 17,565 delay days accumulated. Not all detention is avoidable – vessel delays and structural lags exist – but the share caused by lack of visibility is. Scenarios over the real baseline:

USD 118k/yr

CONSERVATIVE SCENARIO • AVOID 20% OF
DELAY DAYS

USD 206k/yr

ACHIEVABLE SCENARIO • AVOID 35%,
PRIORITIZING LONG DELAYS

+ Recovery

DISPUTING WRONGLY INVOICED CHARGES
WITH AUDITABLE EVIDENCE

The savings mechanism is concrete: the system raises a yellow alert days before free time expires (configurable threshold) and a red alert on the first day of delay, with the accumulated cost and the cost of each additional day in plain sight. The container gets prioritized, shipped or returned earlier. The 16+ day band – 68% of the cost – is the first to disappear, because it stops being possible for a container to spend a month in delay without anyone seeing it.

Additional recovery line: every operation keeps an audited timeline (date, user and detail of each event), carrier-granted waivers are recorded with their net billable amount, and damage is documented with photos on the spot. That evidence is the basis for requesting waivers and disputing incorrect charges with the carriers – impossible to sustain with a spreadsheet.

Assumptions: scenarios computed over the 17,565 delay days of the Aug-2025/Jun-2026 period at the effective average tariff of USD 33.5 per delay day. They exclude dispute recoveries and man-hour savings.

4. The solution

The Container Detention CRM records each container's full life cycle: empty pickup at the depot (free time starts), transit and arrival confirmation at the plant, movements between plants, loading and assignment (booking, vessel, destination), departure by shipment or return, and terminal gate-in confirmation (free time stops and the operation closes). On top of that record, the system computes daily, per container, the remaining free days and the projected cost, using each carrier's current tariff and an urgency traffic light (green / yellow / red).

Module	Function
Home	Dashboard with month-to-date cost, containers at risk, empty stock and live activity
Intake	Batch registration of pickups: paste the container list and one confirmation creates all operations
Outbound	Plant departure by batch (shipment or return) and terminal arrival confirmation
Containers	Full ledger with global search and a per-container file with timeline
Alerts	Expirations sorted by urgency, with traffic light and projected cost
Incidents	Damage documented with photos, linked to the operation
Reports	Excel export of any list, with filters and column selection
Administration	Users and roles, carriers, tariffs and free time with validity history, waivers, plants, depots and alert threshold

The design is not theoretical: it came out of analyzing a full year of real operation (2,804 containers, 417 pickup batches). That is why the system replicates how the team works – batch entry, automatic ISO 6346 validation of every container number, Excel export of any list – and not the other way around. Lists update in real time on every connected screen, and sensitive actions (voids, corrections) require the supervisor role and are logged with user and date.

5. Project status: platform v2 in production

Unlike a proposal yet to be built, this system is deployed to production in its second version and validated against the full history: the calculation engine reproduces **2,804 out of 2,804** containers from the historical record, day by day. Internal test-mode rollout is starting now. There is no development to fund and no delivery deadlines that can slip.

2,944 CONTAINERS OF REAL HISTORY PROCESSED	11,669 TRACEABILITY EVENTS	11 months OF MEASURED BASELINE TO COMPARE SAVINGS AGAINST	14 CARRIERS PARAMETERIZED, WITH VERSIONED TARIFFS AND FREE TIME
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As of July 7, 2026, the system showed 19 containers in delay that had already accumulated USD 29,890 and were adding USD 665 more per day, plus 6 containers in yellow where there was still time to act. That snapshot – impossible to obtain from the spreadsheet – is the operational demonstration of the project's value.

6. Investment and return

- **Development:** complete. No pending build investment.

- **Operation:** minimal-cost cloud infrastructure (hosting and managed database), with no per-user or per-seat licenses.
- **Return:** keeping just two containers per month out of delay covers the system's annual operating cost. Any additional saving – the Section 3 scenarios estimate USD 118–206k/year – is net.
- **Measurement:** savings will be verified monthly with two indicators compared against the historical baseline already loaded: average delay days per container and percentage of operations closed within free time.

7. Implementation plan

Phase	Timeline	Content
1 • Go-live	Weeks 1–2	Walkthrough of the real flows with the operating team – already underway in internal test mode –, fine-tuning, and adoption as the single system of record
2 • Management layer	Weeks 3–4	Automatic weekly email report to management: cost for the period, containers at risk, and progress against the baseline
3 • Continuous improvement	Ongoing	Monthly savings measurement, automatic daily backup of the data, and system evolution driven by the operation

8. Built to scale: from Bahía Blanca to Latin America

Detention mechanics are identical in every port in the world: a carrier-granted free-time allowance and a daily tariff in USD per container. The same global carriers – Maersk, MSC, Hapag-Lloyd, ZIM – operate across the region with the same logic. Only each site's parameters change – and in this system the parameters are configurable data, not code. Wherever Dow exports in containers, free time is running, carrying the same risk Bahía Blanca already measured: USD 588k in 11 months.

Dow has a strong presence in Brazil – its largest footprint in the region – and also operates in the United States, Colombia, Peru, Mexico, Chile and Argentina, among other markets:



What makes replication a matter of weeks rather than a new project:

- **100% parameterized architecture.** Carriers, tariffs and free time (versioned by validity date), day-counting rules, plants and depots are catalogs managed from the interface. Nothing about the Bahía Blanca case is hard-coded.
- **Multilingual out of the box.** Interface and materials in Spanish, Portuguese and English – ready for teams in Brazil, Spanish-speaking America and the United States. This project's executive presentation already operates in all three languages.
- **A proven replication playbook.** Onboarding a new site = loading local catalogs and rules + importing its history. That process was already executed in Bahía Blanca with 2,944 containers and 11,669 events. Estimate: 4 to 6 weeks per site, with the same value-capture plan as Section 7.
- **Marginal cost per site.** No per-user or per-site licenses: the same cloud infrastructure scales, and each site measures its savings against its own baseline.

The prize of scale: the project's value does not end at Bahía Blanca's USD 118–206k/year. Every container-exporting site in the region replicates the measurement – with its own history as baseline – and captures its own savings with the same yardstick.

9. Risks and mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Partial team adoption (double entry: spreadsheet + system)	Supported go-live during the first two weeks and designation of the system as the single record; batch entry makes the system faster than the spreadsheet, not slower
Data continuity	Automatic daily backup of the entire database, included in phase 3 of the plan
Data quality at entry	Automatic ISO 6346 validation of every container, versioned tariffs that are never overwritten, and an audit trail for every correction
Dependence on one person	Documented roles and permissions; delegable administration; operational knowledge lives in the system, not in someone's spreadsheet

10. The ask

We request the **selection and formal adoption of the project**: designating the CRM as the single system of record for the detention operation and approving the 4-week implementation plan described in Section 7. The system, the data and the measurement baseline are ready; the decision unlocks the capture of the savings — and opens the door to the regional replication described in Section 8.

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